it was proving a difficult wicket, but I continued to make progress, and reached 150 by working the ball off my hip through mid-wicket.

Wickets kept falling at the other end, but nobody gave anything away. Dale Steyn batted for more than an hour, at one point driving the spinner for a straight six, and Paul Harris also fought hard, creating time for me to continue my innings ... and I reached my second double century in Tests by striking two boundaries in one over from the agitated Gul.

Even when Paul fell with the total on 477 for nine and my score on 206, Morné Morkel strode out to the crease, put his head down, worked hard and so enabled me to keep moving towards a milestone.

Graeme Pollock had for many years held the record for the highest score by a South African batsman in Test cricket, and it seemed to many that his epic innings of 274 against Australia at Kingsmead in 1970 would duly stand the test of time. Then Daryll Cullinan scored an unbeaten 275 against New Zealand in Auckland in 1999, a score that was matched by Gary Kirsten, batting against England in Durban later that same year. The record stood for four seasons until, in July 2003, Graeme Smith produced his amazing innings of 277 against England at Edgbaston in Birmingham.

Now, in Abu Dhabi in 2010, as our tenth wicket partnership continued to frustrate the bowlers, I edged nearer and nearer to the record. At one point, I started to wonder whether we were going to declare but Graeme let me keep batting, keep moving towards his record. I passed 250 with a straight drive for six, looked across to where my teammates were sitting, and saw our captain standing and leading the applause.

Morné and I added 91 runs in the 11 overs before tea, and as I walked off the field my thoughts drifted back to our home in Bela-Bela, where I knew my mother was spending her birthday, watching the cricket on television, as usual insisting that nobody move while I was batting.

We resumed after the interval and, eager to reach the landmark and get on with the Test, I drove the third ball of the first over after tea for six,